

Home Prices, Rents & Wages in Cabarrus County

How has housing affordability changed over the past two decades?

Cabarrus County has grown rapidly since the mid-2000s, but that growth has come at a mounting cost for residents seeking housing. Median home values and rents have far outpaced income gains, squeezing household budgets and putting homeownership increasingly out of reach. This brief uses U.S. Census Bureau data to track how these trends have unfolded from 2006 through 2023.

+158%

Median home values since 2006, vs. +73% for household incomes

+121%

Annual rents since 2006, roughly 1.7× faster than wages

4.4×

Price-to-income ratio in 2023, up from 2.9× in 2006

Housing Costs vs. Wage Growth, 2006–2023

The chart displays three data series: Median Home Value (blue line), Annual Rent (orange line), and Median Household Income (black line). The Y-axis represents an index where 2006 = 100, ranging from 100 to 250. The X-axis shows years from 2006 to 2023. A shaded gray area from 2008 to 2010 marks the 'Great Recession'. Median Home Value and Annual Rent both show a sharp increase starting around 2012, with a particularly steep rise between 2020 and 2023. Median Household Income shows a more gradual, steady increase over the same period.

Year	Median Home Value (Index)	Annual Rent (Index)	Median Household Income (Index)
2006	100	100	100
2008	120	110	115
2010	115	110	100
2012	115	115	110
2014	120	125	110
2016	140	130	130
2018	155	140	140
2020	180	160	155
2022	245	190	160
2023	260	220	175

Figure 1: Index where 2006 = 100. ACS 1-year estimates were not collected in 2020 (COVID-related disruption).

! Important

The wage-housing gap. Between 2006 and 2023, median home values in Cabarrus County outpaced household income growth by **85 percentage points**. That gap widened sharply after 2012 and accelerated further during the post-pandemic housing surge of 2020–2022.

The Affordability Gap: Home Price-to-Income Ratio

cabarrusdatalab.com Source: U.S. Census Bureau, ACS 1-Year Estimates (2006–2023)

1

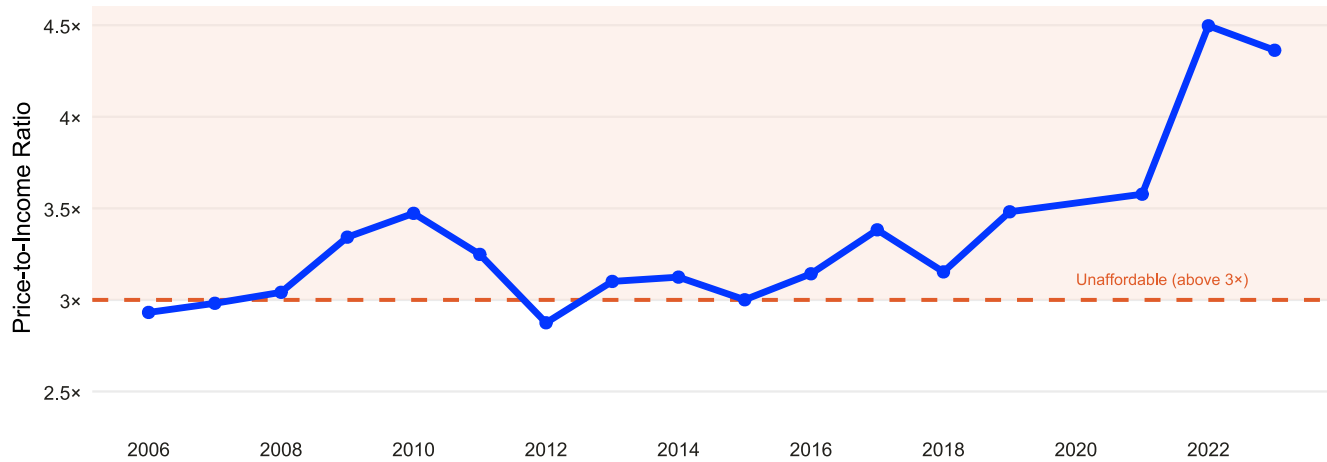


Figure 2: Median home value divided by median household income. Economists traditionally use 3× as the upper boundary of affordability for homeownership.

Year	Home Value	Annual Rent	Median Income	Price/Income
2006	\$145,000	\$8,000	\$50,000	2.9×
2010	\$169,000	\$8,900	\$49,000	3.5×
2015	\$171,000	\$10,300	\$57,000	3×
2019	\$252,000	\$11,800	\$72,000	3.5×
2023	\$374,000	\$17,800	\$86,000	4.4×

i Note

About this brief. Data are drawn from the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS), 1-year estimates, for Cabarrus County, NC. Variables: B25077 (median owner-occupied home value), B25064 (median gross rent), B19013 (median household income). ACS 1-year estimates were not released for 2020. All values are nominal and not adjusted for inflation. The 3× price-to-income threshold follows the convention used by the National Association of Realtors and urban economists.